



**POLL STARS:** The winners swear by development

# GRASSROOTS RISING

The local body polls in the state was both a revolution and a revelation: in a zero-violence voting the established order was uprooted, with 70 per cent of the seats going to women mostly under 30

■ By Farzand Ahmed

Think of elections in Bihar and the images that come to mind are of booth-capturing, bogus voting, mayhem and even murder. But last week, the state witnessed an election which destroyed the hegemony of the dons and politicians over politics at the grassroots. It may be a new beginning for the state. "Call it an emergence of youth power or gender revolution in the state, but it's bound to change the socio-political paradigm in future," said Chief Minister Nitish Kumar who was convinced that his dream of cleansing the system of crooks and political mercenaries may become a reality.

The elections to 118 local bodies—ranging from municipal corporations to nagar panchayats—were not fought

## NEW ORDER

- The recently held elections to 118 local bodies in Bihar has heralded a new era in the state.
- The election, held on a non-party basis, is seen as a trend-setter in a state where polls are normally associated with caste politics.
- Most of the posts went to the youth and women. Candidates backed by political stalwarts and dreaded dons were trounced.
- The government reserved 50 per cent posts for women while 20 per cent were reserved for OBCs, 15 per cent for SCs and one per cent for STs.

on party lines and involved a total of 2,864 posts. The results evoked shock and surprise in political circles. While over 70 per cent of the posts were captured by women mostly under 30, more than half of the remaining posts went to the youth. Said Mohammad Asghar Ali, 23, a first-time ward councillor in Phulwarisharif in the outskirts of Patna, "Neither caste nor religion worked this time. Only those who could convince the voters that they would pursue the politics of development were elected." In fact, the election, held on a non-party basis, is seen as a trend-setter in a state where polls were normally associated with mass murder. The urban voters, like the rural masses in the panchayat elections held in June last year, rejected the candidates backed by political stalwarts and dreaded dons and voted